
Service expectations: the consumer versus the provider

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Reflect for a moment about a favourite restaurant. What is it about the restaurant that makes it special to you? Your personal criteria are based, in part, on your past experience with a number of restaurants. At the same time, the fact that the restaurant is a favourite implies that you have patronized it a number of times. During those previous visits, you learned what to expect while dining there, e.g. how quickly you will be seated and how attentive the waiter will be. Therefore now, when these expectations are fulfilled, your pleasure with the restaurant is reconfirmed. But, what about the provider of the service? Doesn't a waiter at that restaurant also have expectations for the service encounter? Certainly experience has taught him/her what to expect from a typical interaction with a regular customer. This raises the question: how do your expectations for a dining experience at that restaurant compare with those of the waiter?

Discovering the expectations that the participants in a service encounter bring to an interaction is an important prerequisite for understanding perceptions on both sides of the encounter. Yet, to date, there has been no comparison of provider and consumer service encounter expectations, even though expectations anchor satisfaction judgements (Oliver, 1980). The purpose of this study is to address this gap by comparing the expectations of service providers and consumers of the same service. We investigate whether the same components of a service encounter are identified as important by both sets of participants. Do the expectations of a participant on one side of the interaction complement and/or coincide with the expectations of the other? Are both sets of expectations comparably detailed?

In the next section the theoretical background is presented, beginning with a look at expectations for product performance and some of the challenges inherent in using traditional measures of expectations. An alternative operationalization for service expectations, script methodology, is then described and subsequently used in the study. The theoretical discussion is followed by a formal statement of the hypotheses and a description of the study procedures, results, and analysis. Finally, implications for management and future research are discussed.

Theoretical background

Expectations

Expectations for product performance represent an a priori standard which consumers bring to a consumption experience. Consumers compare perceived performance against this preconceived, often subconscious, standard when evaluating a product. The label “expectations” has been used in the marketing management literature to convey a variety of conceptualizations, including ideal “can be”, normative “should be”, and predictive “will be” expectations (see Spreng and Dixon, 1992, for a review). The result has been confusion over the meaning of the term.

There is general agreement, however, that predictive “will be” expectations represent the consumer’s expectations about what will happen in his/her next interaction with the firm (e.g. Boulding *et al.*, 1993; Spreng and Dixon, 1992). This standard stems from past experience with a product category and from the consumer’s perception of typical product performance. Miller (1977, p. 76) tied this reliance on past experience with forward-oriented expectations: “based on past averaged performance ... what the respondent feels performance *will be*” (*sic*).

Measuring service expectations. Measuring performance expectations in service contexts has been problematic. Expectations and perceived performance are often measured at the same point in time, following product consumption. The expectation data are based on recall and are therefore bound by all the limitations inherent in this type of measure. The data are further confounded because it is likely that expectations assessed after product exposure have been swayed by the perceived level of product performance (Carman, 1990). However, informative data are obtainable when expectations are measured prior to product exposure (e.g. Bearden and Teel, 1983; Oliver, 1980). Unfortunately, this constraint drastically limits the accessibility to meaningful measurement of consumer expectations.

An alternative methodology has been proposed for assessing expectations of service experiences. Smith and Houston (1983) suggest that consumer scripts provide an operationalization of “will be” expectations, a standard against which future service interactions can be compared. Scripts have been described as “expectation bundle[s]” (Abelson, 1981) and are especially appropriate for evaluating service encounters because they incorporate both the outcome and process dimensions of the event (Grönroos, 1984; Schank and Abelson, 1977).

Because a script is a current mental representation of a stereotyped sequence of events, it circumvents the problems faced by other measures of expectations including biased recall and product exposure prior to measuring expectations.

Script theory

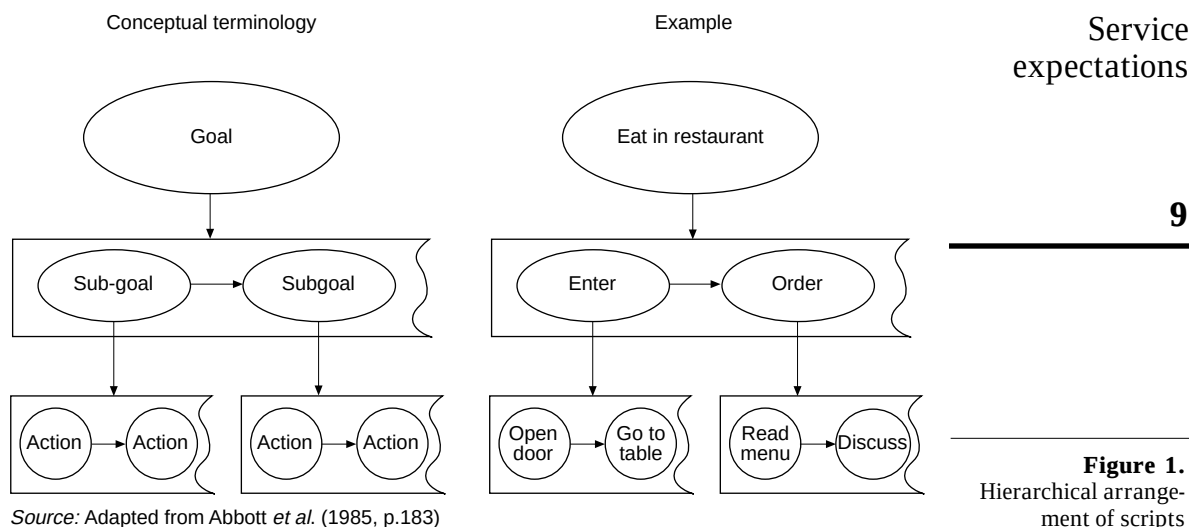
A script is a cognitive structure that organizes sequences of events in a particular context (Schank and Abelson, 1977). As a person experiences daily life, knowledge structures develop which are organized around routine, goal-oriented activities. One's memory economizes on the storage of these recurrent events by retaining a standardized, generalized episode of the event. A script is more than the communication component of an encounter; it is a structured, stereotyped sequence of actions that defines a well-known situation (Schank and Abelson, 1977). A specific script encodes a bundle of information about the goal-directed event, including the standard conditions for entering the activity, sequence of events, roles, props, and normal outcome resulting from the activity (Bower *et al.*, 1979).

Scripts are assumed to define expectations which provide behavioural guides and serve as norms for evaluating others' performances (Mohr and Bitner, 1991; Smith and Houston, 1983). "Strong scripts" include expectations for the sequence as well as the occurrence of events while "weak scripts" do not include sequence expectations (Abelson, 1981). A "situational script" exists when, in a particular context, participants have interlocking roles and share an understanding of what is supposed to happen (Schank and Abelson, 1977).

The idea of a situational script is compatible with role theory (Solomon *et al.*, 1985). In role theory the focus is on the position an individual occupies in a social situation. Based on a dramaturgical metaphor, these "actors" adopt a set of behaviours appropriate to the role. In a marketplace interaction, boundary-spanning personnel take on the role of service provider while the recipient of the service temporarily assumes the "customer" role (Solomon *et al.*, 1985). This example also points to a basic tenet of role theory. Roles are complementary, i.e. defined in relation to other roles: bus driver/passenger, hairdresser/client. For a service encounter to be successful, the participants must be able to predict the actions and behaviours of the other role occupants. This is accomplished through the use of a common script (Solomon *et al.*, 1985).

Script hierarchy. Scripts are organized hierarchically. The purpose for enacting a script is to achieve a goal, such as getting a haircut. One achieves the goal by completing a series of subgoals. A subgoal can be likened to a scene within a play: one of several parts of the whole which must occur for the entire script to make sense and conclude in a satisfactory manner. The subgoal is the level at which people generally describe an event or situation (Abbott *et al.*, 1985). Each subgoal is composed of a cluster of actions. This hierarchy, goal/subgoals/actions, is illustrated in Figure 1[1].

Script activation. Three conditions are necessary for scripted behaviour to occur (Abelson, 1981). First, a person must have a stable cognitive representation of the particular activity, i.e. possess the script. Second, the script



must be evoked by the context. Third, the individual must enter the script, i.e. actually carry out the actions in the script. The point of entry into a script is based on personal experience in the evoking context (Abelson, 1981).

For example, in order to enter an “Eat lunch at McDonald’s” script, the consumer must first know how to enter, order, pay, and obtain food at McDonald’s, i.e. possess the script (first condition). Given the context of a lunch hour (second condition) implying limited time, hunger, and the proximity of a nearby McDonald’s, the consumer may go to McDonald’s for lunch (third condition), i.e. begin carrying out the actions in his/her “Eat lunch at McDonald’s” script.

Script elaborateness. Every action in a service encounter is potentially subject to errors or mishaps. A few may occur so regularly that the participant will add contingencies and corrective actions to his/her script of the encounter. This is the primary way in which scripts expand (Schank and Abelson, 1977). Through these alternative and corrective actions a regular participant will develop an increasingly elaborate script for the encounter.

Providers are regular participants in their service encounter script (Schank and Abelson, 1977). They also enact the script with a wide variety of customers whose idiosyncrasies provide opportunities for the service provider to increase the number of actions or contingencies in his/her script. Customers participate less frequently in specific service interactions and are not as likely to interact with as wide a variety of providers. Thus, it seems likely that service providers possess relatively more elaborate scripts of the encounter than do their customers.

Similarities and differences in participants’ scripts. The complementary nature of the participants’ activities in many service encounters implies that they have similar expectations for typical actions. Therefore, it is likely that the

participants' scripts will be similar. However, each participant is particularly sensitive to the aspects of the situation that are important for successful completion of his/her own script (Leigh and Rethans, 1984a). This may leave a participant indifferent to the portions of the service encounter which are not directly related to his/her function in the interaction. A service provider who is not mindful of the consumers' perspective of the encounter may not attend to all of the factors that are important from the customer's point of view. A likely result is customer-perceived gaps in the service and in service quality.

Research question and hypotheses

Based on this introductory and theoretical discussion, this article addresses the research question: How do the expectations of providers of a service compare with the expectations of consumers of that same service? In many routine service encounters, the production and consumption of the service product occur simultaneously and comprise two sides of the same exchange goal. This leads to the expectation that participants of a service encounter will have the same subgoals. Yet, participants in a service encounter perceive the interchange from different perspectives. Thus, we anticipate that there will be differences in expectations for a service encounter as expressed in the following hypothesis:

H1: Some of the subgoals comprising provider and consumer scripts of a service encounter will coincide, while other subgoals will not be shared.

An individual considers a service encounter to be in process once he/she activates the script for a routine encounter. Entrance into a script is based on a personal policy developed from an individual's experience with the evoking context (Abelson, 1981). Based on these factors, the question emerges as to whether there are differences in the point at which a service encounter script is activated. Are scripts activated simultaneously for the different participants in the encounter? Consider the McDonald's scenario discussed above. What does a customer consider to be the first step in the "Eat lunch at McDonald's" process? The customer performs a number of actions (e.g. stands in line) before the interaction with the attendant begins. Do scripted actions begin as soon as the decision to "Eat lunch at McDonald's" is made, *en route* to the restaurant, ordering the meal, or when the food is actually consumed? By the same token, what does the counter attendant perceive to be the first action in the encounter? Unless both participants perceive the same action to initiate the process, the points of script activation will differ between the two participants.

H2: The point of activation for entrance into a script of a service encounter will differ between consumers and providers.

More complex expectations require a more elaborate script. An elaborate script, one which includes a number of contingencies and corrective actions, is a longer script. We contend that the providers possess more elaborate scripts of a service encounter than consumers because service providers enact their script more frequently and with a greater variety of participants than the consumer.

H3: Providers of a service have more elaborate scripts for the service encounter than do consumers of the service.

Service
expectations

Study design

The hypotheses were addressed in a two-phase study. Phase One was designed to discover and compare the subgoals of providers and consumers of a service encounter (*H1*). Because the subgoals, specifically, were sought, a modified script elicitation procedure was used. This permitted only the most basic actions – that is, the subgoals – to emerge. These subgoal scripts were also used to identify the point of script activation (*H2*).

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The third hypothesis addressed the elaborateness of consumer and provider scripts. In order to compare script elaborateness it was first necessary to identify the subgoals shared by both groups of respondents in Phase One. Once the shared subgoals had been identified, the participants in Phase Two listed the detailed actions comprising their scripts for these subgoals. This two-phase design permitted a more focused study of the elaborateness of the subgoals shared by both the consumers and providers of the service.

Haircuts were selected as the context for the study for several reasons. First, having one's hair cut in a salon is a common experience in which almost everyone participates. In the terminology of the study, it is a service for which almost everyone has a script. It is a service that many people obtain on a fairly regular basis, and one in which most adults have participated for many years. Second, it is a service in which consumers actively participate, owing to its moderately risky nature. Finally, it is generally an important and salient service to college students, the population from which the consumer sample was drawn.

Phase One of the study

Phase One focused on the first two hypotheses. Pretesting with both consumers and providers revealed that the subgoals in a haircut script were encompassed within seven basic actions. Therefore, respondents were asked to list no more than "seven basic steps" in either receiving or providing a typical haircut. (See Appendix for the instruments used.)

Sample

Both customers and providers of the service were surveyed. The sample of consumers consisted of 48 undergraduates enrolled in marketing classes at a large university in the USA. Nine of the scripts were deemed unusable because these consumers possessed a script incongruent with the research question (e.g. a friend cut their hair instead of having their hair cut in a salon). The final sample size of 39 was composed of scripts from 21 males and 18 females.

The service providers were 24 hairdressers who worked in a number of shops within an eight-mile radius of the university. Because it seemed likely that there would be differences based on client gender, each provider furnished two scripts: one for a typical female client and the other for a typical male client

(counterbalanced order). Two scripts were too incomplete to use, yielding a sample size of 46 scripts, 23 for male clients, 23 for female clients.

Analysis and results

Thus, two sets of scripts were obtained, one set from consumers and the other set from service providers. The unit of analysis was the script, which was composed of the subgoals of the respondent's typical haircut. The two sets of scripts were coded separately. Each subgoal mentioned was recorded, yielding a master list of subgoals for each set of respondents. The number of respondents who mentioned each subgoal was then tallied. Descriptive statistics are provided in Table I. Chi-square analysis found no significant gender differences in the frequency of mention of any of the subgoals. A Pearson correlation reflecting the split-half reliability for the frequency of mention of the subgoals was 0.85 for the consumers' scripts and 0.80 for the service providers' scripts, and were thus deemed reliable (Leigh and Rethans, 1984b).

A generic group script[2] was identified for each of the two sets of subgoals. This summary script includes only the subgoals which are most frequently mentioned by the respondents (Bower *et al.*, 1979). The number of actions in a group script depends on the nature of the response frequency of each action. Inclusion of a particular action in the group script is determined by a noticeable gap in the number of respondents who mention each action. Once this gap in response frequencies has been identified, any action which has been mentioned by more respondents than the upper boundary of the gap is included in the group script (Bower *et al.*, 1979).

The consumers' group script included six subgoals. Each of these were mentioned by more than 50 per cent of the consumers while the next most common action was mentioned by only 36 per cent of the consumers, yielding a 14 percentage point gap. The subgoals comprising the consumers' group script were: "Make appointment", "Enter", "Wait", "Wash hair", "Cut hair", and "Pay".

The providers' group script contained five subgoals. Twenty percentage points separated the response frequency of the five subgoals from the other subgoals mentioned by the service providers. The five subgoals constituting the providers' group script were: "Greet client", "Wash hair", "Cut hair", "Pay", and

Table I.
Phase One: descriptive
statistics for subgoals

	Consumer (n=39)	Service provider (n=46)
Total number of subgoals	264	315
Total number of different subgoals mentioned	34	29
Range number of subgoals per script	5-11	3-9
Mean number of subgoals per script	6.76	6.84
Unique subgoals	11	2

“Talk”. The subgoals which compose the group script for the providers and the consumers are listed in Table II, along with the percentage of respondents who mentioned each one.

Comparison of subgoals: group scripts. Three subgoals appeared in the group script of both groups: “Wash hair”, “Cut hair”, and “Pay”. Chi-square analysis was conducted to compare the frequency of mention of the subgoals between the consumers’ and the providers’ scripts, categorized by gender. There were no significant differences in the frequency of mention (Female: “Wash hair” $\chi^2 = 2.461$, $df = 1$, NS; “Cut hair” $\chi^2 = 0.000$, $df = 1$, NS; “Pay” $\chi^2 = 1.333$, $df = 1$, NS. Male: “Wash hair” $\chi^2 = 0.820$, $df = 1$, NS; “Cut hair” $\chi^2 = 0.385$, $df = 1$, NS; “Pay” $\chi^2 = 3.020$, $df = 1$, NS).

Three subgoals appeared in the consumer group script that did not appear in the providers’ group script: “Make appointment”, “Enter”, and “Wait”. “Enter” and “Wait” are actions carried out by the consumer rather than the provider. It makes sense that these are subgoals of the consumers and are not subgoals of the service providers. However, “Make appointment” is an action in which both the provider and the consumer take part. Interestingly, only the consumers listed it in their scripts. Even in shops with only one proprietor, in which the hairstylist him/herself scheduled the appointments, not a single provider mentioned “Make appointment”.

Two subgoals appeared in the providers’ group script that were absent from the consumers’ group script: “Greet client” and “Talk”. Customers certainly do greet their hairdressers and do take part in the conversation that transpires over the duration of the haircut. However, it is the providers who appear to take responsibility for these actions.

A portion of the subgoals of one participant coincide with the subgoals possessed by his/her counterpart in the service encounter, providing evidence of interlocking expectations. However, differences in subgoals were also found. Thus, *H1* was supported.

Point of script activation. The point of activation occurs at the moment an individual enters the script. The consumers’ group script for a typical haircut indicated that the stimulus prompting entry into the script occurred at the

Subgoals	Percentage of respondents mentioning	
	Consumer ($n = 39$)	Service provider ($n = 46$)
Make appointment	51.3	—
Enter	64.1	—
Wait	53.9	—
Greet client	—	100.0
Wash hair	61.5	58.7
Cut hair	92.3	95.7
Pay	79.5	58.7
Talk	—	93.5

Table II.
Group scripts: subgoals

“Make appointment” stage, well before the actual haircut transpired. During the service encounter itself, two of the consumers’ subgoals had occurred (“Enter”, “Wait”) before the hairdressers’ script had even been activated.

The hairdressers’ script for giving a typical haircut started at the point in which the face-to-face interaction with the client actually commenced. This finding was pervasive. Again, even in single proprietorships, not a single provider listed a subgoal occurring before greeting the client in the shop. Nor did any of the providers list any subgoals recognizing their clients’ arrival or wait. These findings support the notion that the point of activation for the exchange goal “Haircut” differed dramatically between consumers and providers. *H2* was supported.

Phase Two of the study

The object of the second phase of the study was to compare the elaborateness of the scripts between providers and customers of a service. Script theory posits that each subgoal is composed of a number of specific, supporting *actions*. Using the subgoals which emerged in Phase One as stimuli, participants in Phase Two were asked to list the actions which comprise each of the subgoals in their typical haircut experience. Respondents were given the option of indicating whether or not specific subgoal(s) were included in their script. No limit was placed on the number of actions they could list.

Sample

Consumer scripts were elicited from 64 students in four marketing classes at the same large university in the USA using a self-administered questionnaire. Twenty-three were deemed unusable because these consumers possessed a script incongruent with the research question (e.g. a friend cut their hair instead of having their hair cut in a salon). The final sample of 41 usable scripts comprised 27 females and 14 males.

Hairdressers were recruited from salons other than those solicited in Phase One in order to ensure new service provider respondents. Participants were offered a nominal monetary incentive. Thirty-three respondents provided actions for a typical male client and separately for a typical female client. A final sample size of 64 usable scripts (32 male, 32 female) was obtained.

Analysis and results

The data consisted of two sets of scripts, one for consumers and one for providers. Each set of actions was coded separately, subgoal by subgoal. Overall intercoder reliability for the actions was 0.97 for the consumer scripts and 0.91 for the service provider scripts. Chi-square analysis identified few gender differences in the frequency with which actions were mentioned. The significant differences that did occur were appropriate and not unexpected. For example, “curl hair” was mentioned by service providers when referring to female clients, but was never mentioned when referring to male clients.

Group scripts were developed for the actions within each subgoal for each set of scripts. Actions that were mentioned by more than 20 per cent of the sample were included in the group script (see Leigh and McGraw, 1989). Table III presents the summary statistics for the actions of each subgoal. Included are:

- the number of respondents who provided actions (i.e. included the subgoal in their script);
- the total number of different actions mentioned by all the respondents;
- the number of unique actions mentioned (i.e. actions mentioned by only one respondent);
- the number of actions in each subgoal's group script;
- the mean number of actions respondents listed;
- the range of the number of actions listed by the respondents;
- the intercoder reliability;
- split-half reliability[3].

In order to test *H3*, consumer and provider group scripts were compared across the three subgoals that were common to both groups: "Wash hair", "Cut hair", and "Pay". Chi-square analysis was used to assess the difference in elaborateness in each of these three subgoals. Elaborateness was operationalized for each group by the number of actions mentioned in each subgoal (Leong *et al.*, 1989).

The number of actions mentioned in the subgoals was compared (see Table IV). Providers listed significantly more specific actions in the subgoals "Cut hair" ($\chi^2 = 38.029$, $df = 1$, $p < 0.001$) and "Pay" ($\chi^2 = 21.53$, $df = 1$, $p < 0.001$)

Subgoals of encounter participants	<i>n</i>	Total number actions	Actions		Actions per respondent		Intercoder reliability	Split- reliability
			Unique actions	Number in group script	Mean	Range		
<i>Consumer (n = 41)</i>								
Make appointment	33	30	9	6	3.0	1-08	0.96	0.95
Enter	41	26	11	3	3.2	2-06	0.99	0.86
Wait	40	24	9	2	2.5	1-07	0.98	0.98
Wash hair	35	38	13	12	5.7	1-15	0.99	0.87
Cut hair	41	48	19	9	4.9	2-09	0.94	0.66
Pay	41	26	16	4	4.1	2-10	0.95	0.93
<i>Provider (n = 64)</i>								
Greet customer	63	44	11	10	4.8	1-12	0.90	0.74
Wash hair	60	57	19	14	6.9	1-18	0.94	0.70
Cut hair	64	96	34	10	7.6	1-21	0.88	0.71
Pay	58	45	9	9	5.3	1-09	0.94	0.87

Table III.
Actions of service
encounter participants

than did consumers. The number of actions mentioned by the two groups for the “Wash hair” subgoal was not significantly different ($\chi^2 = 2.001$, $df = 1$, NS). Consumers may have an equally elaborate script of the “Wash hair” subgoal because they perform that activity frequently themselves.

A qualitative assessment of the shared subgoals revealed additional evidence that providers possess more elaborate scripts. Providers were considerably more explicit in their descriptions of the haircut itself, using a total of 23 different terms for cutting hair as shown in Table V. The actions mentioned by the consumers in the “Cut hair” subgoal were quite basic with only five different terms used.

The results generally support *H3*. Service providers’ scripts were more elaborate for two of the three subgoals shared with consumers.

Discussion

Substantively, this study offers several insights for the services and script literatures. It is the first study in which consumer and individual service provider expectations have been compared using script methodology. The findings provide evidence that participants in a service encounter bring different perspectives to the encounter (Mohr and Bitner, 1991). The data support the notion that participants in the service encounter possess some unique subgoals, while other subgoals are shared by both consumers and service providers.

The hypothesis that the perceived point at which an encounter begins differs between consumers and providers was supported by the data. These results indicate that there were components of what the consumer considered to be a part of the “service encounter” which were not reciprocated by the service

Table IV.
Number of actions in
shared subgoals: con-
sumers and providers

Subgoal	Consumer	Service provider	χ^2	<i>p</i> -value
Wash hair	234	404	2.00	ns
Cut hair	202	485	38.03	0.001
Pay	169	341	21.53	0.001

Table V.
Illustration of script
elaborateness (for
“cut” subgoal)

Service providers				Consumers
Begin	Use guide	Right side	Front	Begin
Back	Hairline	Left side	Short	Cut
Blend 1	Cut inch	Sides	Perimeter	Sides
Blend 2	Interior	Texturize	End	Top
Blend 3	Layer	Around ears		End
Top	Cut	Progression		

provider. This was simply because, from the provider's perspective, the encounter had not yet begun. These portions of the service encounter call for more attention from management in order to render a more satisfactory experience for the customer.

Provider expectations were more elaborate for the portions of the service interaction for which providers and consumers had shared subgoals. In no instance were consumer expectations more elaborate than provider expectations. This finding leads to some interesting possibilities for service providers, as discussed in the implications section.

Methodologically, the data support the notion that scripts operationalize expectations. Script methodology overcomes many of the problems inherent in the traditional measures of expectations. Because a script is an individual's stereotyped sequence of actions that comprise a familiar activity, operationalizing expectations by having a respondent list the actions in his/her script does not constitute a recall measure. Respondents are describing a typical, i.e. expected, service encounter, rather than recalling a specific interaction. The issue of prior product exposure becomes irrelevant using this methodology. Script methodology offers the additional advantage of indicating respondents' breadth of experience through the elaborateness of their scripts.

Various limitations of the research may have affected the findings. First, only two judges were used to code the scripts. These judges were not blind to the purpose nor to the hypotheses of the research. Second, convenience samples were used. Efforts were made to sample from salons quite heterogeneous in appeal and to avoid including only hairdressers who cater primarily to university clientele. Third, students served as the consumers in the study. While the sample was relatively homogeneous, the service context certainly is salient to this consumer group. Nevertheless, caution should be exercised in generalizing the results.

Managerial implications

The nature and results of this study offer several recommendations for management. Awareness of the difference in the points of script activation suggests that more attention may need to be focused on the point at which the consumer enters the script. Identification of the point of consumer script activation may illuminate opportunities for additional marketing efforts. For example, knowing that the consumer considers him/herself beginning the process of a service at the time the appointment is being scheduled may have ramifications for the way in which incoming calls scheduling appointments are handled. The person answering the telephone may be instructed to give the caller his/her undivided attention and to bend over backwards in accommodating the consumer's preferences.

Eliciting scripts from customers is a natural companion to service mapping (Kingman-Brundage, 1989; Shostack, 1984). Customer-provided scripts can be especially useful in developing a service map or blueprint. For example, as the findings of this study demonstrate, the customer may consider the point at

which the service encounter begins to be quite different from what management might assume. Customer scripts highlight what is important to consumers, and may help the service manager develop, maintain, or enhance a customer-oriented focus. Consumer scripts may also lead to the identification of gaps in service which may not be apparent to those managing the service. Because each participant attends to what is important to the successful completion of his/her own script, gaps may occur when the consumer is at a point in the process which is in between the designated "jurisdiction" of specific service providers. An obvious example is a patient waiting in a medical office. The receptionist may have completed her scripted encounter by having the patient complete some necessary paper work. Meanwhile, the patient waits because the nurse's or doctor's script has not yet begun. This gap between service provider scripts contributes to patient waiting time. If service maps are developed solely from the point of view of the provider, these lapses may not be evident or their influence on consumer perceptions of the process may be underestimated.

It may be beneficial for managers to be aware of the very great difference between consumer and contact employee scripts. Obtaining customer scripts may reveal expectations which are not currently being met. On the other hand, it may reveal that customers are not aware of some of the benefits that are being provided (Levitt, 1981). In order to elucidate benefits, it may be helpful for service providers to mention potentially hidden services in the course of conversation with the consumer or in literature distributed to them. For example, if a protein strengthener is sprayed on a client's hair before the haircut, the hairdresser could call attention to it. Otherwise, customers may assume that it is only water used to moisten the hair. Consumer satisfaction is likely to be suboptimal when the customer is unaware of service benefits or when the provider is failing to meet customer expectations.

Scripts can also be used as an additional resource tool in the employee recruitment and selection process. During interviews, for example, potential service providers could be asked to explicate the steps they would expect to execute in serving customers. The elicited point of activation and elaborateness could help the recruiter determine the interviewee's experience and customer orientation relative to the job being filled.

Employee training can also be enhanced through the use of scripts. Scripts from exceptional employees may provide insights into the details which set their service apart and make an impact on customers. These scripts could provide a template for other employees. In using script methodology, compiling individual scripts, e.g. a group script, can be useful for identifying the most common steps in a procedure. However, much can be learned from those subgoals not mentioned as frequently. These subgoals may point to innovations in service delivery or to segmentation opportunities.

Future research

Findings of this study support the notion that a comparison between consumer and service provider expectations via scripts is worthwhile. A natural follow-up

study would be to compare expectations across service encounter dyads, i.e. a comparison of scripts between service providers and their own customers. This type of research would extend the understanding of complementary scripts to a comparison of the specific expectations for a service encounter held by a service provider and his/her own customer(s).

Comparing expectations for service encounters between exemplary and inexperienced employees would allow researchers to contrast elaborate and relatively basic expectations. This could provide insights into the evolution of contingencies, enriching our understanding of expectations and, methodologically, script formation.

Future research should also address the relationship between script elaborateness and consumer satisfaction. Does a more elaborate consumer script (i.e. contingency-based expectations) provide a more flexible route through the service encounter? If so, does a more elaborate consumer script lead to a higher likelihood that the customer will be satisfied? Or does an elaborate customer script imply that expectations are simply more detailed, requiring essentially customized service in order to satisfy? Are these scenarios mutually exclusive?

Previous research findings show that successful sales personnel possess more elaborate scripts than do unsuccessful sales personnel (Leigh and Rethans, 1984a). Does this phenomenon also apply to providers in a service encounter? Do service providers whose scripts include more contingency options provide a more customized service encounter? Does a more contingency-based provider script yield greater customer satisfaction for customized services? For standardized services (cf. Sutton and Rafaeli, 1988)? The use of scripts methodology in future research would aid in providing answers to these important issues.

Conclusion

Differences in the expectations of consumers and service providers are one of the major sources of misunderstandings in service encounters. This study's methodology, applied in a services context for the first time, enables the researcher or manager to elicit and study the scripted expectations of both parties in a service encounter. The promising results of this study will hopefully encourage dyadic and other forms of needed research on this important topic.

Notes

1. The script literature utilizes a specialized terminology. For example, a goal is referred to as a *script header*, a subgoal is labelled a *scene header*, etc. Since this study focuses on service expectations rather than script methodology, the use of scripts terminology is minimized.
2. Also known as a "scripted norm" (e.g. Leigh and Rethans, 1984b).
3. One of the subgoals unique to providers was "Talk". Unlike the actions in the other subgoals, the actions in "Talk" were iterative and were mentioned numerous times throughout the course of the service interaction. The actions were not sequential, and there was an extremely high percentage of unique actions. Thus, the actions in "Talk" represented a weak script (Abelson, 1981) and was therefore excluded from the rest of the analysis.

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Appendix

This study required four different script elicitations: two from consumers (for Phase One and Phase Two) and two from service providers (for Phase One and Phase Two). The instrument used was modified for each of the four elicitations. Shown below are the instructions to both the respondents in Phase One.

Instructions to the consumers

People expect familiar patterns when entering certain situations. These patterns can be described in terms of basic steps. For example, the basic steps of the typical experience of going out to eat may include:

- Enter restaurant
- Look at menu
- Order
- Eat
- Pay
- Leave

We are interested in the basic steps you expect when you go to get your hair cut at a hair salon. Please list the seven basic steps in your typical haircut experience.

Instructions to the hairdressers

Service providers follow familiar patterns when serving their customers. These patterns can be described in terms of major steps. For example, the major steps used by a bank teller when serving a customer could be:

- Call next customer
- Greet the customer
- Take forms
- Process forms
- Return forms and/or cash
- Bid farewell

What are the major steps you perform when you give a customer a hair cut? Please think about a typical hair cut appointment for a female client and for a male client.

On the back of this form please list the "Major steps" in a typical hair cut you provide for a male client and a typical hair cut you provide for a female client.

In Phase One, only the subgoals were sought. Pretests conducted with customers and hairdressers found that a haircut was generally perceived to be made up of seven or fewer subgoals. Thus, both Phase One questionnaires provided only seven response lines while no limitation was placed on the number of actions respondents could list in Phase Two. Subgoals for male customers and for female customers were elicited from hairdressers in two separate sections. Hairdressers were instructed to focus on hair cut appointments, and to exclude steps involving hair colouring, permanents, or other services. Customers were asked to provide their gender and whether or not they typically have their hair cut in a salon.

Additional information may be obtained from the authors.